



CURLEY-CUES

BY BOB CURLEY

There was a time when athletes took pride in their ancestry. It was listed, along with their other credentials, in yearbooks of the baseball register variety.

Things have changed. Buy a current baseball register and it lists just about everything but a player's ancestry. The chances are that the 1974 books will even report wife swapping information.

To illustrate its opposition to what it termed "ridiculous" ethnic quotas in schools, the Jewish Defense League brought "ancestry" back into the baseball picture. Last week the JDL conducted sit-ins at Shea and Yankee Stadiums.

The organization is asking that baseball teams each hire six Jewish players — or 25 per cent of the roster — to "show how ridiculous it is to judge people on ethnic backgrounds."

Now the JDL has to be intelligently super ridiculous.

Just finger back through your memory and, if you can name 10 Jewish baseball players, you're "good." Name 20 and you'll receive an "excellent" rating.

It's apparent that young Jewish athletes either didn't dig baseball or could not sustain an active interest in the sport.

Parental influence could have been a major factor. The good mothers, who had invested in violin or piano lessons, weren't going to have their offspring injured in pursuit of a round hunk of horsehide. Then, too, many of the Jewish parents were business people and needed junior around their stores to help with many chores.

If the Jewish boys didn't care for baseball, they channeled their athletics into other sports of the handball (an easy way to break a finger) or basketball.

Being well-versed in business tactics, young Jewish athletes realized that minor league baseball life was not good business. The salaries were low and it was a long haul into the majors.

Today it's a lot quicker from the minors and we have the likes of Ron Blomberg, Mike Epstein and Art Shamsky digging for all of that diamond gold.

The Jewish ghettos of yesteryear were not conducive to developing baseball players, but they did produce some of the finest men to ever wear boxing gloves.

Back in the days of the Polo Grounds and Ebbets Field, management was always on the hunt for Jewish baseball talent. They felt, that since the majority of the prospective fans in The Bronx and Flatbush were Jewish, having a player of that ancestry would help to pack the parks. It wasn't long before the baseball brass found that the Sid Gordons and Cal Abrams were few and far between.

It's quite obvious that in 1973 the Jewish Defense League would have a difficult time coming up with 12 players for the Yanks and the Mets to employ.

Look back at random to the 1955 Baseball Register of the "Game's 400." That season only three players were of Hebrew ancestry: Gordon, of the N.Y. Giants; Abrams, of the Brooklyn Dodgers, and Al (Flip) Rosen, of the Cleveland Indians. Two minor league prospects of the faith were Hyman Cohen, a pitcher for Des Moines, and Saul Rogovin who was up from Havana for a shot at a job with the White Sox.

In other baseball registers of other years, they mention Harry Feldman, who was involved in the Mexican League jumping; Andy Cohen, Billy Goodman, Morrie Arnovich, Hank Danning, Hank Greenberg, Phil Weintraub, Buddy Rosar, Al Levy, Ival Goodman, and, of course Sandy Koufax.

Fingering through that 1955 register was a delight. There was a photo of a smiling Danny O'Connell, who was getting ready for his fourth major league season. There was a complete biography on a kid by the name of Roberto Clemente, whom the Pirates had drafted from Montreal. It was also to be the first full year for Harmon Killebrew at Washington, where he had failed to hit a homer in nine games the previous year.

As for added bits of ancestry information, the book reminded us that Ted Williams was of Welsh-French descent; Mickey Mantle, Dutch-Irish. Nothing really "X" rated about that.

Now the JDL has a point in its push for taking a players' ancestry out of the folder of "secret information." The JDL will not win its current drive. As a matter of fact, probably the only time a player or umpires' ancestry is mentioned in ball parks these years, the language would be strictly unfit for publication.

Millie phoned to tell us about her family. "My grandfather was always called a heel, but my grandmother said he was a loafer."